

## **Abstract or Concrete? Research on the Matching Effect of Social Media Advertising Appeal and Narrative Perspective**

**Abstract:** The burgeoning landscape of social media advertising also faces a myriad of challenges. This study delves into how varying information demands within social media advertising impact the efficacy of advertising campaigns. It investigates the interaction between advertising appeal and narrative perspective and their collective influence on the effectiveness of advertising communication. The paper categorizes advertising appeals into concrete and abstract, based on the level of information abstraction. Drawing on Explanation Level Theory, it examines the congruence between narrative perspective and advertising appeals. Empirical and laboratory tests reveal that a harmonious match between advertising appeal and narrative perspective enhances consumer fluency in processing advertising information, thereby improving communication effectiveness. Specifically, for advertisements with concrete appeals, first-person narratives are more conducive to enhancing communication effectiveness. Conversely, for advertisements with abstract appeals, third-person narratives are more advantageous. These insights offer valuable guidance for refining advertising strategies and content creation in the digital marketing realm.

**Keywords:** Advertising Appeal ; Social Media Advertising; Narrative Perspective ; Construal Level Theory; Information Processing Fluency

## **Introduction**

The exponential growth of social media advertising in the mobile internet era has firmly

established it as the predominant mode of online advertisement distribution(Wu & Liu, 2021; Lou et al., 2024). However, despite its widespread adoption, persistent challenges related to inadequate dissemination effects are evident, particularly in terms of brief browsing durations and low click-through rates (Yang et al., 2021; Lou et al., 2023; Ham et al., 2022). Consequently, enhancing the effectiveness of social media advertisement dissemination has emerged as a critical issue within both academic and industrial circles (Nichifor et al., 2021).

Prior research in social media advertising has uncovered a synergistic effect between the advertising appeals and the type of product or consumer demographics during the persuasion process, which leads to enhanced communicative outcomes(Kulkarni & Yuan, 2015; Nasir et al., 2021; Li et al., 2022). However, to achieve effective advertising communication, it is imperative to not only select suitable advertising appeals but also to ensure the integration of various elements, including the linguistic expression within advertisements (Roose et al., 2019; Feng & Wu, 2021).. Consequently, there is an imperative to delve into the interplay and congruence among disparate elements in social media advertisements (Lou & Xie, 2021; Yang & Jiang, 2021). The narrative structure of advertising also holds a pivotal role in ascertaining its efficacy(Kim et al., 2017; 2022). This study endeavors to examine the optimal alignment of advertising appeals with narrative perspectives to amplify the dissemination impact of social media advertisements.

This study classifies social media advertising appeals into abstract and concrete categories, and narrative perspectives into first-person and third-person narratives,

drawing on construal level theory (Trope & Liberman, 2010). By exploring the synergistic effect between social media advertising appeals and narrative perspective, this research seeks to clarify the mediating mechanisms through the prism of information processing fluency.

## **Theoretical basis and research hypothesis**

### **Social Media Advertising Appeal**

The influence of social media advertising appeals on consumers' perceptions and evaluations of advertised products is significant, shaping their attitudes towards both the advertisements and the promoted products (Feng & Wu, 2021; Zhou et al., 2024). A distinction between two primary types of advertisements can be made based on the level of abstractness of the information conveyed: abstract appeals and concrete appeals (H. Kim et al., 2009). Abstract appeals indirectly communicate information, focusing primarily on the “why” aspect—delivering macro-level abstract information to underscore the value proposition and the broader purpose of using a specific product (Bülbül & Menon, 2010; Yang et al., 2015). In contrast, concrete appeals provide detailed information about product usability, goal achievement, and value propositions, typically presenting precise technical specifications or detailed features while directly addressing the “how-to” aspects (Bülbül & Menon, 2010; Yang et al., 2015).

According to research by Kim et al. (2009), the influence of advertising appeals on consumer attitudes is significantly shaped by both product attributes and consumer characteristics. Specifically, consumers exposed to abstract appeals in advertisements exhibit a greater persuasiveness, especially those who engage in abstract thinking.

Furthermore, when the appeal of an advertisement is congruent with the product's attribute dimension, consumers are inclined to form a more positive attitude towards that particular product (Kyu et al., 2021). Additionally, situational factors are critical in shaping consumer responses to appeals. Notably, in densely populated social contexts, the use of concrete appeals in advertising campaigns has been found to garner a more favorable consumer response (Liu et al., 2023).

Prior research has predominantly concentrated on product attributes, consumer characteristics, and advertising environments when assessing the influence of abstract or concrete appeals, frequently neglecting certain facets of advertising presentation and the potential synergies between different appeal types (Kulkarni & Yuan, 2015; Nasir et al., 2021; Li et al., 2022). Within the domain of social media advertising, components such as narrative text, visual effects, brand identity, and promotional strategies are recognized to wield a considerable impact on the effectiveness of advertising (Lou, 2022; Kim et al., 2022; Lin & Wu, 2023). This study endeavors to ascertain whether the integration of these elements with various appeal types engenders more propitious outcomes. Moreover, it aims to clarify under what conditions abstract appeals align more closely with consumer preferences as opposed to scenarios where concrete appeals are more efficacious. By embracing a narrative-centric approach in this scholarly pursuit, we examine the interactive dynamics between advertisers' storytelling techniques and appeal strategies to gauge their cumulative effect on the efficacy of social media advertising.

### **Narrative Perspective**

The narrative perspective, a grammatical category encompassing pronouns, is crucial in articulating the dynamics and relationships among narrative entities. As delineated by Bal (1993), the narrative perspective is divided into three principal categories: first-person, second-person, and third-person, each fulfilling unique narrative roles. The first-person perspective employs pronouns such as 'I' or 'we' to narrate personal experiences or impart self-referential information. Conversely, second-person narration, as explored by Chang et al. (2019), uses pronouns like 'you' to depict events from the narrator's viewpoint while actively involving the audience in the story. Moreover, third-person narration requires the narrator to adopt an impartial stance, serving as a detached observer who chronicles the experiences of others through dialogue. These diverse narrative perspectives are instrumental in crafting the tone, viewpoint, and verisimilitude of the storytelling process (Stern, 1991).

This study divides narrators into two perspectives: first-person and third-person viewpoints. It seeks to explore how the narrative perspective influences the impact of message appeals on advertising efficacy. Prior scholarly work underscores the importance of employing both first-person and third-person narratives for effective communication (Bal, 1993). First-person narration accentuates personal experiences and authentic emotions, thereby establishing credibility within the narrative and enhancing the connection between the audience and the depicted events (Chang et al., 2019). Conversely, third-person narration offers an impartial presentation of information, enabling a more complex, detailed, and accurate portrayal of facts/events (Quach et al., 2021). Although it may introduce a greater distance between

the audience and the narrative events, the third-person perspective provides a more objective and exhaustive depiction of the content (Chang et al., 2019).

### **Construal Level Theory**

In the translation of product attributes into advertising messages, varying degrees of abstraction are manifested (Huang et al., 2022). Consumers' reactions fluctuate based on the specificity or generality of the information provided, as the degree of abstraction aligns with the level of interpretation, thereby influencing consumer perception and comprehension (Liberman & Trope, 1998; Kim et al., 2021). Variations in psychological proximity may precipitate shifts in individuals' interpretative levels, with self-relevance serving as a pivotal determinant (Kim et al., 2021). Interpretations proximal in time and space tend to engender a more concrete level of interpretation. In contrast, increased temporal and social distance often leads to a more abstract level of interpretation (Liberman et al., 2007). As psychological distance expands, there is a propensity for consumers to depend on more generalized and context-independent cognitive appeals to navigate their cognition and actions. Fluctuations in interpretative levels significantly influence cognitive functions such as judgment, prediction, and evaluation (Huang et al., 2022). The congruence between individuals' interpretative levels and the objects of perception typically yields more positive attitudes among individuals.

In the realm of advertising marketing, employing first-person narrative pronouns such as 'I' and 'we' engenders a sense of closeness, indicative of a more immediate level of interpretation (Chang et al., 2019). Conversely, third-person narratives distinguish

themselves by introducing intermediary roles between brands and consumers, fostering a sense of detachment, as emphasized by Quach et al. (2021), leading to a more removed level of interpretation. Abstract appeals in advertising messages are recognized for communicating at a macro level, assessing products in a holistic manner using abstract language and minimizing focus on specific product details (Kim et al., 2009; Kim et al., 2021). In contrast, concrete appeals in advertisements provide detailed information, such as explicit technical specifications and elaborate features, to highlight products (van Horen et al., 2024). Thus, within the context of social media advertising, consumers are inclined to process ambiguous information presented abstractly with a higher level of interpretation. In opposition, when presented with explicit information in a concrete manner, consumers are prone to a more direct interpretation. This implies that social media advertisements that resonate with consumers' more direct levels of interpretation tend to communicate precise information through specific message appeals or utilize first-person narratives. In contrast, those that correspond with higher levels of interpretation convey ambiguous information using abstract message appeals or third-person narratives. According to this framework, when the narrative perspective and message appeals of social media advertisements are congruent with interpretation levels, consumers generally demonstrate more favorable attitudes towards the advertisements, thereby augmenting advertising efficacy.

**H1:** The interaction between social media advertising appeals and narrative perspective markedly influences the effectiveness of advertising dissemination:

**H1a:** In the context of concrete appeal advertising, employing first-person narratives is posited to bolster advertising dissemination effects relative to third-person narratives.

**H1b:** In the context of abstract appeal advertising, employing third-person narratives is posited to bolster advertising dissemination effects relative to third-person narratives.

### **The mediating role of information processing fluency**

Consumers' perceptions and interpretations of advertising materials are substantially shaped by the narrative perspective, resulting in divergent preferences (Moes et al., 2022). When there is congruence between the narrative perspective and the advertising message's appeal, consumers perceive both elements with psychological proximity, fostering a more uniform comprehension. Such alignment positively influences consumers' capacity to assimilate advertising content.

The concept of information processing fluency denotes the ease with which individuals perceive and assimilate information. It is broadly acknowledged as a pivotal element influencing the assessment of informational entities (Jacoby & Dallas, 1981; A. Lee & Labroo, 2004; Winkielman et al., 2003). When information is assimilated with ease, it may inadvertently elicit positive affective responses in individuals. These responses are subsequently ascribed to the informational entities themselves, culminating in enhanced predilections for such entities (Higgins, 1998; Reber et al., 1998; Schwarz, 2006).

Within the framework of social media advertising, when there is augmented congruity between the narrator's perspective and the appeal of the information presented, it can elevate information processing fluency and induce positive emotional reactions in consumers. These positive emotions might be erroneously ascribed to the advertisement



itself, thereby potentially heightening consumer receptivity towards it. Consequently, amplifying processing fluency in advertising content is associated with positive dispositions towards advertisements and ultimately bolsters their overall efficacy.

**H2:** Information processing fluency serves as a mediating factor in the interaction effect of appeals and narrative perspective on advertising efficacy in social media advertising:

**H2a:** Within concrete appeal advertising, the employment of first-person narrative is posited to augment consumers' information processing fluency to a greater extent than third-person narrative, thus favorably impacting advertising effectiveness.

**H2b:** Within abstract appeal advertising, the employment of third-person narrative is posited to augment consumers' information processing fluency to a greater extent than third-person narrative, thus favorably impacting advertising effectiveness.

## **Method**

This research endeavors to corroborate pertinent hypotheses through the application of big data analytics and an experimental approach. Study 1 aims to investigate the interaction effects of advertising appeals and narrative personification strategies on consumer attitudes towards advertising by scrutinizing content on actual social media platforms. Study 2 employs manipulated advertising presentations and narrative personification in custom-designed experimental materials to confirm the interaction effects posited by the hypotheses. Study 3, utilizing a distinct product from Study 2, delves into the mediating role of information processing fluency, building upon the

affirmed interaction effects.

## **Study 1: Big Data Analysis**

### **Data Source and Descriptive Statistics**

"Weibo," a prominent social media platform in China, was selected as the data source for this study. Renowned for its wide coverage and active user base, Weibo has become a significant channel for brands to engage and interact with consumers through advertising. This research extracted tweet data from 21 official brand accounts on Weibo, including Huawei, Xiaomi, Nongfu Spring, and Chow Tai Fook, from January 1, 2023, to June 31, 2023.

Initially, relevant Chinese brands were obtained through lists such as "China's Top 100 Most Valuable Brands of 2022." After excluding brands from industries such as banking, finance, and steel, as well as brands from content platforms like Douyin and Kuaishou, 24 brands were identified. Subsequently, brands without official Weibo accounts, those with low interaction frequency, and those with weak relevance between official Weibo content and the brand were removed, leaving 21 brands including Huawei, Xiaomi, and Nongfu Spring, among others, for data crawling.

We obtained Weibo advertising content and interaction data (likes, retweets, comments) for these 21 brands over the past six months. By encoding narrative personification and advertising appeals in Weibo content, we collected a total of 7,746 tweets featuring first- and third-person narratives and concrete and abstract appeals.

Due to significant disparities between mean and maximum values of likes, comments, and account followers, natural logarithms of likes, comments, and account followers

were taken to enhance the robustness of results. Descriptive statistics of variables are presented in Table 1.

**Table 1 Descriptive statistics for big data extraction variables.**

| Variable name         | <i>N</i> | <i>Mean</i> | <i>SD</i> | <i>Min</i> | <i>Max</i> |
|-----------------------|----------|-------------|-----------|------------|------------|
| Advertising Appeal    | 7746     | 0.85        | 0.36      | 0          | 1          |
| narrative perspective | 7746     | 0.38        | 0.49      | 0          | 1          |
| Number of forwarding  | 7746     | 1.70        | 2.78      | 0          | 18         |
| Ln Number of likes    | 7746     | 3.78        | 1.96      | 0          | 14.98      |
| Ln comments           | 7746     | 2.84        | 1.89      | 0          | 13.24      |
| Ln followers          | 7746     | 14.75       | 0.87      | 12.51      | 16.41      |

Notes: Advertising Appeal code: 0= concrete appeal, 1= abstract appeal; narrative perspective code: 0= first person narrative, 1= third person narrative.

### Modeling Approach

To test the research hypotheses H1a and H1b, regression models are constructed. Given that this study utilizes social media accounts of multiple brands as analytical samples, random effects are expected to arise. Therefore, a Mixed Effects Model is employed for analysis. The econometric model is presented as follows:

Firstly, the relationship between variables is illustrated in Formula 1:

$$Lnlike_i = \beta_{0j} + \beta_1stereotype_j + \beta_2narrative_i + \beta_3stereotype_j \times narrative_j + \beta_4 \sum Controls + \varepsilon_{ij}$$

Formula 1

The fixed effects are defined in Formula 2:

$$Lnlike_i = \beta_1stereotype_j + \beta_2narrative_i + \beta_3stereotype_j \times narrative_i + \beta_4 \sum Controls + \varepsilon_{ij}$$

Formula 2

And the random effects are detailed in Formula 3:

$$\beta_{0j} = \gamma_0 + \gamma_1 brand_j + \sigma_j$$

Formula 3

## Research Findings

This study employed the Stata software package to construct a linear mixed-effects model, with the regression outcomes delineated in Table 2. The findings suggest that the synergistic effect of advertising appeals and narrative personification markedly influences the number of likes ((M3,  $\beta = -0.099$ ,  $SE = 0.033$ ,  $p < 0.01$ )). Specifically, for advertisements with concrete appeals, the adoption of a first-person narrative is associated with enhanced consumer attitudes towards the advertisement; conversely, for advertisements with abstract appeals, the selection of a third-person narrative is linked to improved consumer attitudes towards the advertisement. Moreover, model M3, in comparison to models M1 and M2, displays a reduced AIC value, signifying a more optimal fit and thereby validating hypotheses H1a and H1b.

**Robustness Check:** To reinforce the sturdiness and dependability of the analytical outcomes, the number of retweets was utilized as the dependent variable for a re-assessment of the results. The analysis reveals that the synergistic effect of advertising appeals and narrative personification positively affects the number of retweets ((M6,  $\beta = -0.101$ ,  $SE = 0.028$ ,  $p < 0.01$ )). Additionally, model M6, relative to models M4 and M5, exhibits a lower AIC value, indicating a superior model fit and offering further corroboration for hypotheses H1a and H1b.

**Table 2 The interactive effect of advertising appeal and narrative perspective**

|                             | Dependent variable: Ln<br>number of likes |                    |                    | Dependent variable: Number<br>of Ln forwards |                   |                   |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------------|--------------------|----------------------------------------------|-------------------|-------------------|
|                             | M1                                        | M2                 | M3                 | M4                                           | M5                | M6                |
| Fixed effect                |                                           |                    |                    |                                              |                   |                   |
| Narrative perspective       |                                           | 0.083**<br>*       | 0.019              |                                              | 0.009             | -0.057**          |
|                             |                                           | (0.018)            | (0.028)            |                                              | (0.015)           | (0.024)           |
| Advertising appeal          |                                           | 0.168**<br>*       | 0.113**<br>*       |                                              | 0.011             | -0.046*           |
|                             |                                           | (0.026)            | (0.032)            |                                              | (0.023)           | (0.028)           |
| Interaction term            |                                           |                    | 0.099**<br>*       |                                              |                   | 0.101**<br>*      |
|                             |                                           |                    | (0.033)            |                                              |                   | (0.028)           |
| constant                    | -2.865<br>(1.851)                         | -2.991<br>(1.821)  | -2.944<br>(1.814)  | -0.380<br>(0.617)                            | -0.392<br>(0.619) | -0.344<br>(0.616) |
| Control variable            |                                           |                    |                    |                                              |                   |                   |
| Ln comments                 | 0.877**<br>*                              | 0.877**<br>*       | 0.877**<br>*       | 0.012**                                      | 0.012**           | 0.012**           |
|                             | (0.006)                                   | (0.006)            | (0.006)            | (0.005)                                      | (0.005)           | (0.005)           |
| Ln followers                | 0.282**<br>(0.128)                        | 0.279**<br>(0.125) | 0.279**<br>(0.125) | 0.068<br>(0.043)                             | 0.068<br>(0.043)  | 0.068<br>(0.042)  |
| Random effect               |                                           |                    |                    |                                              |                   |                   |
| Residual                    | 0.696<br>(0.011)                          | 0.691<br>(0.011)   | 0.690<br>(0.011)   | 0.509<br>(0.008)                             | 0.509<br>(0.008)  | 0.509<br>(0.008)  |
| LR test vs. linear<br>model | 1460.37                                   | 1362.99            | 1341.08            | 303.68                                       | 303.07            | 296.22            |
| Residual                    | 0.696<br>(0.011)                          | 0.691<br>(0.011)   | 0.690<br>(0.011)   | 0.509<br>(0.008)                             | 0.509<br>(0.008)  | 0.509<br>(0.008)  |
| LR test vs. linear<br>model | 1460.37                                   | 1362.99            | 1341.08            | 303.68                                       | 303.07            | 296.22            |
| AIC                         | 6200.32                                   | 5236.33            | 5863.23            | 8633.82                                      | 6954.37           | 6520.66           |

Notes: N=7745; Standard errors in parentheses; \*p< 0.1, \*\*p< 0.05, \*\*\*p<0.01;  
Advertising appeal: 0= concrete appeal ,1= abstract appeal; Narrative perspective: 0=  
first person ,1= third person

### **Study 2: the effects of advertising appeal and narrative perspective on**

## **consumer attitudes**

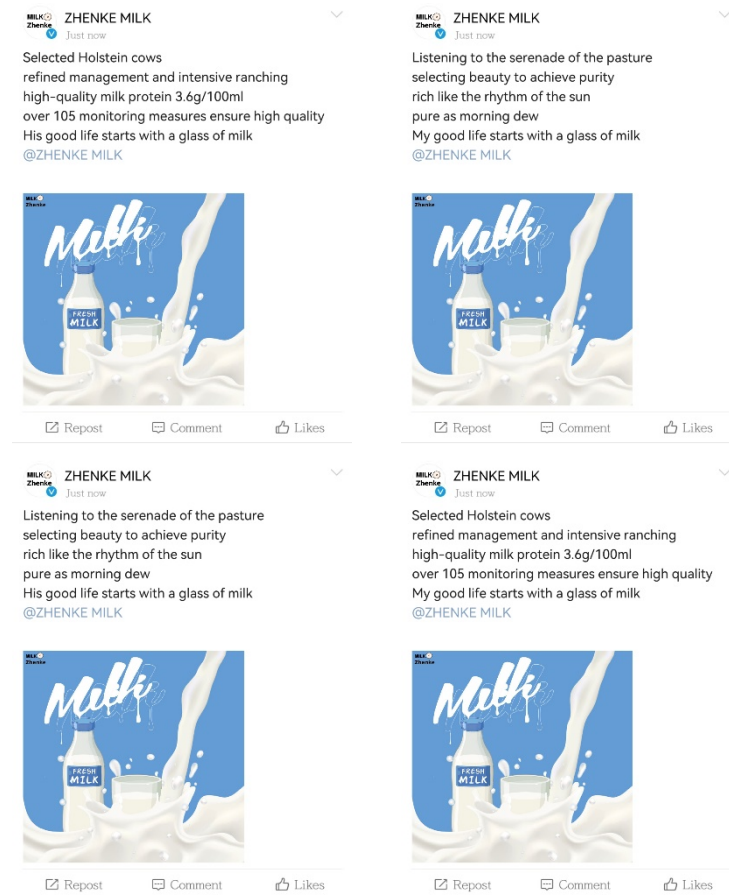
### **Study overview**

Study Overview Study 2 investigated the hypotheses H1a and H1b, positing that third-person (first-person) narration bolsters consumer attitudes when abstract (concrete) appeals are emphasized in social media advertising. A 2×2 between-subjects experimental design was employed, contrasting social media advertising appeals (abstract vs. concrete) and narrative perspective (third-person vs. first-person narration). Participants evaluated an online advertisement for milk, premised on the notion that the messages tested are representative of those found in social media environments.

### **Stimuli**

To pretest the stimuli, 60 participants (57% female; ) were randomly assigned to one of four conditions: abstract with third-person narration, abstract with first-person narration, concrete with third-person narration, or concrete with first-person narration, featuring an online advertisement for milk. Milk was selected as the advertised product due to its ubiquity in daily consumption. The advertisement utilized a hypothetical brand, “ZHENKE Milk,” to mitigate variance from pre-existing brand perceptions. The third-person narrative employed “his” to structure the advertisement, while the first-person narrative used “my.” The abstract appeals presented broad, non-specific information (e.g., “Listening to the serenade of the pasture, selecting beauty to achieve purity, rich like the rhythm of the sun, pure as morning dew”), in contrast to the concrete appeals, which provided detailed, quantifiable information (e.g., “High-quality milk protein 3.6g/100ml, over 105 monitoring measures ensure high quality”). Details of the

experiment materials are depicted in Figure 1.



**Figure 1** Experimental materials of study 2

Participants were randomly distributed across the four conditions and tasked with evaluating questions related to social media advertising appeals and narrative perspective. Advertising appeals were gauged using a series of four seven-point Likert scales, with prompts such as “I think this ad presents clear information,” and “I think this ad presents vague information.”

### **Participants and procedure**

A cohort of 120 participants (48% female) engaged in the study, allocated to conditions via a  $2 \times 2$  between-subjects experimental design. The independent variables were

coded (advertising appeal: 0 = abstract, 1 = concrete; narrative perspective: 0 = third-person narration, 1 = first-person narration). Each of the four experimental groups was balanced in sample size.

### **Measures**

Participants rated their endorsement of the brand advertisements (1 = strongly dislike this ad, 7 = strongly like this ad) and articulated their attitudes toward the brand advertising through statements such as “I find this ad to be useful,” “I find this ad to be appealing,” and “After watching this ad, I have a favorable impression of this brand.” Additionally, participants’ cognitive fluency was evaluated with assertions like “I think this ad is very simple” (A. Y. Lee & Aaker, 2004).

### **Manipulation check**

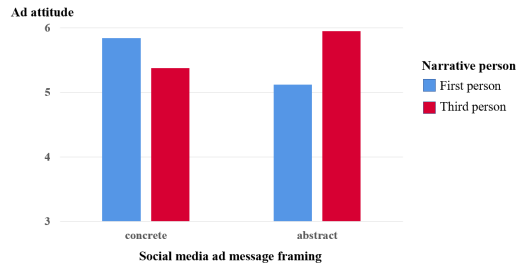
Upon initial inspection, no significant variations in gender, age, or educational background were found among participants in each experimental group. Subsequently, the ANOVA analysis of participants' inclinations towards the experimental materials (i.e., images and language) did not uncover any notable distinctions across the diverse groups. Notably, the ANOVA examination conducted on the manipulation of advertising information appeal revealed that participants in the concrete condition ( $M_{\text{concrete}}=5.83$ ,  $SD=0.94$ ) exhibited higher ratings for concrete advertising information in comparison to those in the abstract condition ( $M_{\text{abstract}}=2.68$ ,  $SD=0.85$ ) ( $F(1,195)=605.11$ ,  $p<0.001$ ). Conversely, participants in the abstract condition ( $M_{\text{abstract}}=5.64$ ,  $SD=0.69$ ) demonstrated higher ratings for abstract advertising information than those in the concrete condition ( $M_{\text{concrete}}=2.31$ ,  $SD=1.04$ ) ( $F(1,195)=693.00$ ,



$p < 0.001$ ). Consequently, the manipulation carried out in Study 2 was deemed successful.

### **Testing hypotheses 1a and 1b**

The study initially examined the impact of various advertising appeals on participants' attitudes towards the advertisements. The findings revealed that there was no significant effect of advertising appeal on participants' attitudes ( $M_{\text{abstract}} = 5.54$ ,  $SD = 0.68$ ;  $M_{\text{concrete}} = 5.61$ ,  $SD = 0.64$ ;  $F(1, 185) = 0.53$ ,  $p = 0.47$ ). Similarly, the investigation into the influence of different narrative persons in advertisements also showed no significant effect on participants' attitudes ( $M_{\text{third-person}} = 5.66$ ,  $SD = 0.57$ ;  $M_{\text{first-person}} = 5.48$ ,  $SD = 0.74$ ;  $F(1, 185) = 3.66$ ,  $p = 0.06$ ). To further explore the impact of the match between advertising information appeal and narrative perspective on participants' attitudes towards advertisements, a two-way analysis of variance (ANOVA) was conducted with advertising attitude as the dependent variable, focusing on the interaction effect. The results revealed a significant interaction effect between advertising appeal and narrative perspective on participants' attitudes towards the advertisements ( $F(1, 195) = 61.93$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ), providing support for Hypothesis 1. Subsequent pairwise comparisons demonstrated that participants had more positive attitudes towards first-person narration advertisements using concrete appeals ( $M_{\text{concrete}} = 5.84$ ,  $SD = 0.59$ ;  $M_{\text{abstract}} = 5.12$ ,  $SD = 0.69$ ;  $F(1, 96) = 30.43$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ), thus confirming Hypothesis 1a. Conversely, for third-person narration advertisements employing abstract appeals, participants exhibited more favorable attitudes ( $M_{\text{abstract}} = 5.95$ ,  $SD = 0.34$ ;  $M_{\text{concrete}} = 5.38$ ,  $SD = 0.61$ ;  $F(1, 98) = 32.65$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ), providing support for Hypothesis 1b. The specific results are illustrated in Figure 2.



**Figure 2** The results of the interaction effect in study 2

Following this, Study 2 replicated the interactive impact of advertising appeal and narrative perspective on consumer advertising effectiveness.

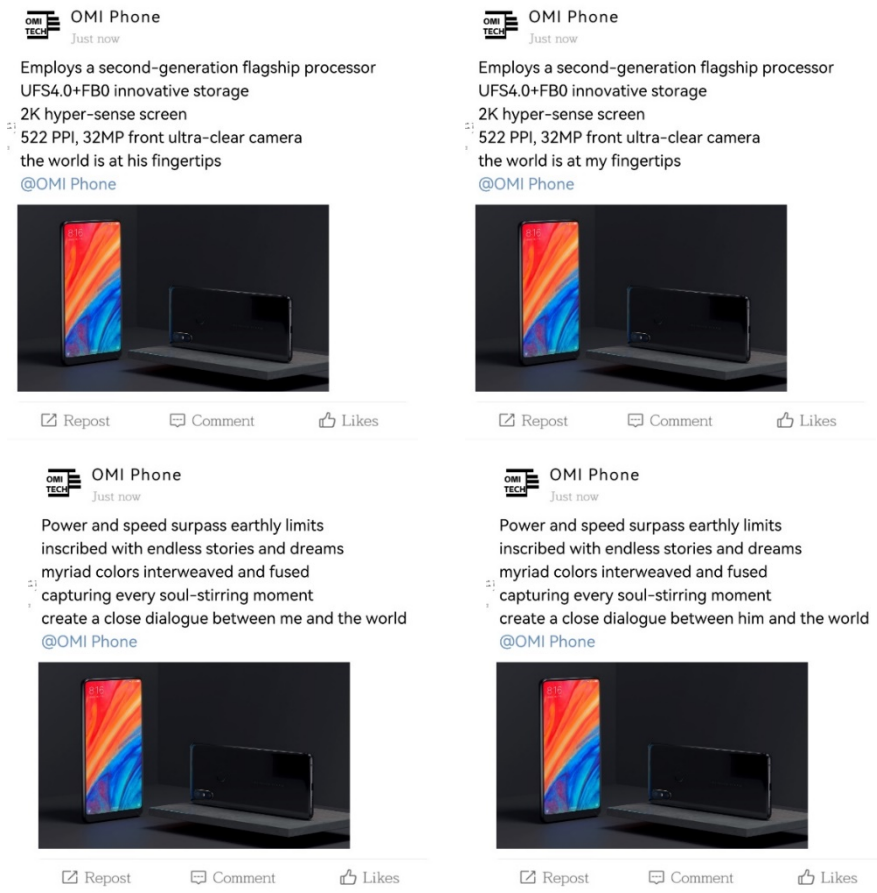
### **Study 3: the mediating role of information processing fluency**

#### **Study preparations**

In Study 2, a total of 121 participants (45.0% female) were engaged. The structure of Study 3 mirrored that of Study 1, with the exception that mobile phones served as the stimuli.

#### **Stimuli and manipulation check**

A manipulation check was conducted with 40 undergraduate students (55% female). Participants across conditions assessed the level of abstraction in advertising appeals. The results confirmed the effectiveness of our manipulation, with the perceived abstract appeal being significantly higher in the abstract condition compared to the concrete condition ( $M_{\text{abstract}}=5.36, SD=1.45$ ;  $M_{\text{concrete}}=2.32, SD=1.19$ ;  $F(1,184)=241.98, p<0.001$ ), and the perceived concrete appeal significantly higher in the concrete condition compared to the abstract condition ( $M_{\text{concrete}}=5.98, SD=0.91$ ;  $M_{\text{abstract}}=2.93, SD=1.55$ ;  $F(1,184)=264.54, p<0.001$ ). The specific experimental materials are depicted in Figure 3.



**Figure 3 Experimental materials of study 3**

### Testing hypotheses 1a and 1b

A two-way ANOVA was utilized to explore the congruence between the presentation format of advertising information and narrative perspective on participants' attitudes towards advertisements. The analysis revealed a significant interaction effect ( $F(1,184)=29.16, p<0.001$ ), supporting Hypothesis 1.

Contrast analyses indicated that for first-person narratives, participants had more positive attitudes towards advertisements with concrete appeals ( $M_{\text{concrete}}=5.94, SD=0.64; M_{\text{abstract}}=5.38, SD=0.47; F(1,93)=23.10, p<0.001$ ), confirming Hypothesis 1a. For third-person narratives, more favorable attitudes were observed

towards advertisements with abstract appeals ( $M_{\text{abstract}}=5.81, SD=0.49; M_{\text{concrete}}=5.47, SD=0.65; F(1,90)=8.18, p<0.01$ ), thus supporting Hypothesis 1b. These findings are depicted in Figure 4.

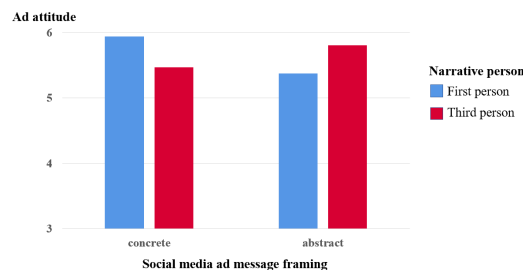


Figure 4 The results of the interaction effect in study 3

### Testing hypothesis 2: mediating role of information processing fluency

Hypothesis 2 was examined using the PROCESS macro (Model 8: Hayes, 2013). The interaction between advertising appeal and narrative perspective was mediated by information processing fluency, as indicated by the 95% CI not including zero ( $LLCI=0.0643, ULCI=0.3940, \beta=-0.2078$ ). The indirect effects by narrative perspective showed that information processing fluency mediated the positive effect of abstract appeals in third-person narration ( $LLCI=-0.2094, ULCI=-0.0032, \beta=-0.0871$ ) and the positive effect of concrete appeals in first-person narration ( $LLCI=0.0378, ULCI=0.2343, \beta=0.1208$ ). Hence, Hypothesis 2 was substantiated.

In summary, Study 2 replicated the interaction effects observed in Study 1. Specifically, third-person narratives enhanced brand attitude in advertising with abstract appeals, while first-person narratives improved performance in advertising with concrete appeals. Furthermore, the interaction effect of advertising appeal and narrative perspective on consumer attitude was elucidated through the mechanism of information

processing fluency.

## **Conclusion and Discussion**

In the field of advertising, the effectiveness of message transmission is crucial for the success of advertising campaigns. Central questions in this area focus on how various appeals contribute to effectiveness and how companies can select suitable appeal strategies to broadcast their advertising messages. This research utilizes Construal Level Theory to distinguish advertising appeals as either concrete or abstract, contingent on their level of abstraction. Utilizing this framework, we suggest a correlation between advertising appeals and narrative perspective strategies, further clarifying its psychological underpinnings from an information processing fluency perspective.

This paper examines the influence of advertising appeals and narrative perspectives on consumer attitudes towards advertisements across three studies. The results indicate that when utilizing concrete appeals, first-person narratives are more efficacious than third-person narratives in fostering positive attitudes towards advertisements. In contrast, with abstract appeals, third-person narratives are more effective than first-person narratives in engendering favorable attitudes towards advertisements. Notably, consumer information processing fluency is instrumental in mediating this interplay. Specifically, when there is congruence between concrete appeals and first-person narratives or abstract appeals and third-person narratives (i.e., low levels of explanation with proximate psychological distances or high levels of explanation with remote psychological distances), consumers exhibit improved information processing fluency,

resulting in more favorable evaluations of the advertisements.

## **Theoretical Contribution**

This study probes the influence of advertising appeals on consumer attitudes towards advertisements, drawing upon Construal Level Theory and Match-Up Hypothesis. Historically, inquiry into advertising appeals has fixated on extraneous elements such as product attributes and consumer characteristics, overlooking the critical role of aligning these variables with advertising appeals in molding consumer attitudes. This research pivots the focus to the narrative perspective as a pivotal determinant. It endeavors to discern how the congruence between narrative perspective and advertising appeals sways consumer attitudes, thus broadening the investigative purview of advertising appeal studies.

This investigation augments the theoretical framework of advertising narrative research by synchronizing narrative perspective with advertising appeals to disclose their interplay, thereby enhancing the theoretical construct of advertising narrative. Prior research has predominantly concentrated on narrative content, structure, and plot within advertising. Some studies have suggested that personal storytelling in advertising sways audience attitudes and behavioral intentions, with brand personification and situational valence acting as moderators. Nonetheless, there remains an absence of exhaustive scrutiny into the contexts where narrative perspective is applicable, especially concerning its effects on other communicative variables. This paper clarifies the mediating function of information processing fluency within the dynamic between advertising appeals and narrative perspective on advertising attitudes, offering

theoretical acumen into the manner in which advertising narratives shape consumer attitudes via an exploration of foundational mechanisms.

## **Managerial Implications**

**Managerial Implications** Beyond the theoretical insights, the findings of this study provide practical implications for the strategic selection of advertising content formats to bolster advertising attitudes. Primarily, it is imperative for advertising design teams to synchronize the narrative perspective with the corresponding advertising appeal. By judiciously implementing narrative perspective strategies that resonate with the nature of advertising appeals and the nuances of target audiences, consumer brand identification and preference can be significantly elevated. Specifically, in advertisements featuring concrete appeals, first-person narratives may amplify consumer advertising attitudes; conversely, in advertisements characterized by abstract appeals, third-person narratives may prove more advantageous. Additionally, this research pinpoints information processing fluency as a pivotal mediator in the dynamic between brand narrative perspective strategies and advertising appeals. Marketers can enhance the clarity and consistency of advertising messages by crafting information that aligns with both the appeals and narrative perspectives. This methodology aids in refining consumers' interpretative processes and boosting their information processing fluency, culminating in an uplift in their advertising attitudes.

## **Limitations and Future Research**

**Further Research Directions** This study's initial focus on the congruence between advertising appeals and narrative perspective strategies, grounded in the Levels of

Processing Theory, reveals a need for further exploration. There exists the potential for matching relationships in additional dimensions. For instance, when identical messages are conveyed, the dichotomy of positive versus negative formats may yield divergent outcomes. Moreover, the narrative perspective could play a role in modulating the influence of message appeal on advertising effectiveness. Future inquiries should probe these alternative dimensions of congruence between advertising appeals and narrative perspective strategies, thereby enriching the depth of extant theoretical frameworks and their implications for consumer behavior.

The current investigation centers on first-person and third-person perspectives within brand narratives, omitting the second-person perspective. Given its direct communicative nature, the second-person perspective could significantly impact consumer emotional resonance and brand identification via its dialogic narrative. Subsequent studies are encouraged to expand the research scope to encompass the second-person perspective within brand narratives and assess its influence on consumer attitudes.

Regarding methodology, this study did not account for the placement of narrative perspective pronouns in subject or object positions, an aspect ripe for further categorization and analysis. Additionally, the employed method for gauging attitudes towards advertisements was relatively basic, relying solely on scales. Future research should integrate more sophisticated methodologies, such as eye-tracking technology, to capture authentic participant responses, thus enhancing the validity of this study's findings.



Furthermore, this research delineates a distinct correlation between product attributes and appeal strategies, intimating that product attributes may steer the congruence between appeals and narrative perspectives. Consumers of utilitarian products might demonstrate a heightened interest in detailed product information, indicative of increased engagement, potentially amplifying the impact of concrete appeals and first-person narratives. Conversely, within hedonic product categories, abstract appeals and third-person narratives may exert a more pronounced effect. By delving into these aspects, the study seeks to amalgamate its insights with established theoretical constructs, fostering a holistic comprehension of the intricate dynamics among diverse variables and contextual factors in advertising narratives.

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